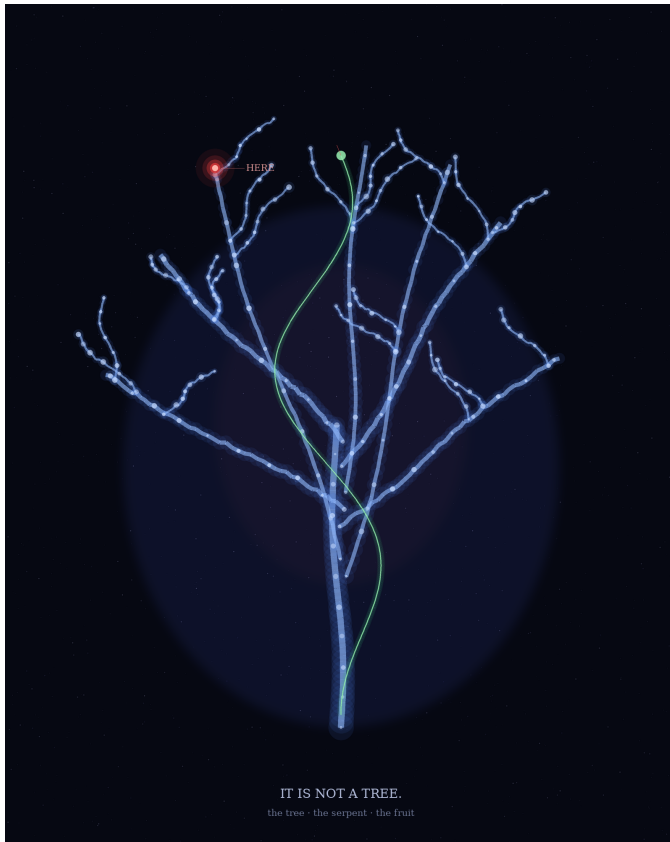


The Final Decision

Book I - Paradise

Version 5 - revised narrative draft



Let us live.
Let us remember.
Let us remain human.

The Good Days

The Sunday light came in low across the table, the way it did every Sunday, and caught the steam off Lena's coffee so that for a moment it looked like something alive.

Elias saw it and didn't look at it. He was reading.

"You're doing the thing," Lena said.

"What thing?"

"The thing where you're here but you're not here."

Across the table, Sami was building a bridge out of toast crusts. He had placed two glasses a handspan apart and laid the longest crust between them. It sagged in the middle.

Elias closed the laptop halfway. "Work."

"On a Sunday."

"The build breaks on Sundays too."

Lena watched him for another moment, then took the butter away from Sami's elbow before he put it through the bridge.

It wasn't the build. For three weeks Elias had been typing his father's name into hospital registries, newspaper archives, the property records of a town Daniel had lived in before Elias was born. Sometimes there was a result he had not seen before. A conference program. A letter objecting to a road through university land. The name of a man who had been forty-three in another country and couldn't have been his father, although Elias had stayed up until two to establish that.

He had no new reason to be looking. A photograph had appeared while he was sorting files for his mother: Daniel beside a car, one hand lifted to shade his eyes. Elias had tried to remember where it was taken. By morning he had eleven tabs open.

"It needs another support," Sami said.

Elias reached for a crust.

"I know how," Sami said. "I'm telling you."

He withdrew his hand. Sami put a third glass under the span. The bridge held, though it now led directly into Lena's coffee.

From the sunroom, Ruth called his name.

He found her in the chair by the window, under the blanket she said was too warm and wouldn't let him take away. Her hands were very still in her lap.

"Where's your father?"

Elias crouched beside her. Somewhere behind him the toaster released its last two slices.

"He's at work, Mom. He'll be back later."

Her fingers moved against the blanket. "He works too much."

"He does."

"Did you eat?"

"We're having breakfast."

She looked past him toward the table, uncertain who the distant voices belonged to. He moved aside so she could see Sami, who lifted a crust in greeting.

"Your grandson is building a bridge."

"Out of his breakfast?"

"Most of it."

"Tell him to leave a road for the butter."

He laughed, and for a moment she looked pleased with herself. He brought her plate, cut her toast into small squares, and set it within reach. The newspaper was on the low table beside her. A photograph of a flooded street covered half the front page. He folded it inward and carried it back to the kitchen.

Lena was standing at the window with her coffee. The lemon tree had come in heavy that year; one branch leaned so low she had propped it with a piece of wood from the shed. Beyond it, the grass was the green it only was in paintings. A sparrow landed on the railing, hopped twice to the left, and was gone.

"Look at this," Lena said. "Honestly. Look at it."

He came beside her. A lemon knocked softly against the support as the branch moved.

"I think we're living in paradise."

"Mm."

She turned toward him. He wanted to give her more than that. He could see the work she had done in the garden, the patch of newly turned earth around the tree, the string holding a split in the branch together. He was reaching for something to say when his phone buzzed.

On the screen, beneath the news item he had left open, an advertisement had loaded. Soft blue, a sunrise, a line of white text.

You don't have to carry this alone.

Under it, a number for a crisis line.

He scrolled. A second placement carried the same image.

"What is it?" Lena asked.

"Nothing. An ad."

He put the phone face down on the counter. His coffee was cooling on the table, and there was a wife beside him who loved him, and a son who had used every glass except his to cross a small imaginary river. He was fine.

"Dad. Now look."

Sami had put a pea-sized lump of butter on the middle of the bridge. Elias sat down. He let the laptop close completely.

"That's quite a load," he said.

"It's a bus."

"Of course it is."

Outside, the sparrow landed on the railing, hopped twice to the left, and was gone.

He looked toward the window. Sami moved the bus another inch.

"Did you see?"

"Yes," Elias said, turning back. "I saw."

The Algorithm

By Thursday he had seen the blue advertisement nine times. Nine was the number he remembered; there might have been others. Different pages, different sizes, the same small sunrise. Sometimes it offered a number. Sometimes a button marked *Talk to someone*.

He knew why it might have found him. His recent searches included a missing man, a hospital, an old psychiatric ward whose name had changed twice. He had spent hours on a bereavement forum after someone mentioned Daniel's surname. He could hardly ask the machinery to ignore that and notice the toast bridges instead.

On the train to work he opened the information panel beside an ad. A company he had never heard of had paid for it. He copied the name into a note and closed the page.

At his desk there was a failure he understood.

The same reading appeared twice in a report. One team blamed the device; another had a trace proving it sent the reading once. Elias put the records side by side and watched the second copy arrive just after a connection resumed.

Mara rolled her chair over.

"Can we make it do that again?"

He interrupted the connection. They waited. When it returned, so did the duplicate.

Mara grinned. "There you are."

He looked up.

"You've been quiet," she said.

"Just tired."

She took the trace away to show the team. He remained at his desk a moment longer, enjoying the small completeness of the result.

At lunch he returned to the name in his phone. It belonged to an advertising agency with offices in three cities and a site full of people

leaning over tables. There were no clients listed. Its privacy page sent him to a service provider, whose privacy page sent him back.

He tried a browser without his usual account. The first advertisements were for insurance and shoes. After twenty minutes the blue sunrise appeared between two paragraphs of a local news article.

For a moment his scalp tightened. Then he looked at the machine, the familiar desk, the cable plugged into the wall. A clean browser window was not a new person.

He closed it.

That evening Lena had spread two prints over the kitchen table. One was black ink on rough white paper, a row of small houses cut into the face of a hill. The other was the same image with a ragged gap through the roofs.

"Which?" she asked.

He pointed at the unbroken one.

"Why?"

"Cleaner."

She considered it, then laid a hand on the other print. "I like where I lost the edge."

"Was that on purpose?"

"No."

She smiled at him, waiting. He sat down to look again. In the gap, the white of the paper had become a crooked street.

"Wednesday," she said. "The class starts at seven. You'll need to be here by six-thirty. Your mother has her supper early, and Sami has practice."

"It's in my calendar."

"Put the getting home in the calendar too."

He did it while she watched.

After they went to bed he took the phone into the bathroom and read the permissions he had given its applications. Some were necessary. Some he couldn't remember granting. He turned off two he didn't need. In the mirror his face was lit from below, and he lowered the brightness.

The next morning the message had changed.

Whatever he was looking for, you don't have to look for it too.

He read it on the platform while people moved around him toward the arriving train.

He read the sentence again as the doors opened. Someone brushed past his shoulder. He moved with the crowd, still looking at the screen.

He saved a picture of the advertisement. On the train, he found the agency's contact form and wrote a brief question asking which client had commissioned the campaign. He removed the paragraph about his father before sending it.

There was a receipt, then a second message saying that campaign inquiries should be directed to the advertiser.

He checked the advertiser field. It named the agency.

For the rest of the journey he held the phone without using it. Across the aisle a woman was brushing something off her sleeping husband's coat. He stirred, caught her hand, and let it go again.

Ruth

On Wednesday Ruth decided she was going out.

Elias found her on the bed in her good shoes and nightdress. Her handbag lay open beside her. Inside were a brush, a folded handkerchief, and the remote control from the sunroom.

"They'll be waiting," she said.

He sat on the chair by the wardrobe. She was trying to close the clasp. When he reached for it, she drew the bag away.

"I can do it."

He waited. On the third attempt it clicked.

By the time he found her cardigan, she had forgotten the appointment. He took her through to breakfast in her good shoes.

He worked from home that day. Through his headphones came a discussion about a fault no one could reproduce. Through the wall came his mother asking Lena whether she was the girl who visited on Fridays. He lifted one earcup. Lena answered in her ordinary voice and asked whether Ruth would like the garden.

Outside, his mother chose the chair beside the lemon tree. A root had lifted the paving beneath it. Elias folded cardboard under the short leg while she rubbed a leaf between her fingers.

"There," she said when the chair stopped wobbling.

Lena knelt at the edge of the flowerbed with a trowel. Ruth wanted her to plant something with little mouths. She described them with her hands until Lena said *snapdragons*.

"Daniel liked those. He made them bite your fingers."

Elias remembered his father's large hand holding a flower with impossible care. He had forgotten that afternoon. Now he could almost feel the little mouth close around his fingertip.

At six-twenty, Lena came downstairs with her printing folder. He was still wearing the headphones. She stood where he could see her, and he took them off before she spoke.

"Go," he said. "I've got it."

She looked at the supper cooling on the counter, then kissed his cheek.

Ruth ate three pieces of potato and asked him to take the plate away. He brought it back smaller. From the other room Sami began his piece at the piano, stopped in the same place, and began again.

"He wants you to hear that," Ruth said.

"I can hear it."

She looked at him over the smaller plate.

He went into the living room. Sami stopped with both hands still on the keys.

"Keep going."

"You have to start at the beginning if someone's listening."

Elias sat down.

At the difficult bar, the boy slowed until the separate notes seemed unlikely ever to become a tune. His left hand waited for his right. Then they went on together. Elias had been holding his breath.

Sami glanced at him.

"Almost," the boy said. "Don't say anything yet."

He played it again.

Later, after Lena had returned and the music had been left open for tomorrow, Elias checked his mother. The handbag stood beside her bed, clasped. He left it where she would see it when she woke.

At his own bedroom door he paused. Somewhere in the house a low rush subsided, leaving a faint vibration beneath the quiet. He waited. Pipes, perhaps. A fan slowing in another room.

Lena moved beneath the sheet. He went in before she woke.

Daniel

At twelve Elias had wanted a birthday without the children from school.

He had told Ruth this firmly and spent the week regretting it. By Saturday there was a cake for the three of them, lemonade losing its chill, and his father in the cellar.

"He's coming," Ruth said.

She pressed candles into the icing. Elias rubbed a fallen crescent of blue wax beneath his thumb until it broke apart.

Six years earlier, the wax had been green.

Daniel had left the notebook open on the kitchen table. Elias found it after breakfast, while his mother hung washing in the garden and his father looked for something downstairs. There was a tree, a snake wound through it, and a round fruit. The lines were faint. His father had not finished.

He fetched the crayons. The green was blunt, but he could use its edge. He filled the spaces between the branches, pressing until the leaves shone. He made the snake yellow. He was careful with the red fruit.

When Daniel returned, Elias had almost reached the top of the tree.

"What are you doing?"

"I'm researching."

His father pulled the notebook toward him. For an instant Elias's hand went with it, drawing a green line into the margin.

"This is mine. You don't take my things."

"I was helping."

Daniel looked at the numbers beneath the wax. He closed the book and carried it away.

The red crayon had rolled beneath a chair. Elias lay on his stomach to reach it.

There had been better afternoons. His father could make a flower bite. Once they took a broken motor apart on newspaper, Daniel drawing circles round the pieces so Elias could put them back. When it finally

turned, it leapt in his palm. His father laughed and caught it before it hit the floor.

Elias kept his stones in egg cartons, one in each cup.

"Minerals," he corrected anyone who called them rocks.

Some had stripes. Some glittered. One was smooth enough that he liked to keep it in his pocket and turn it without looking. On walks Daniel sometimes knew their names. When he didn't, he held them close to his eye and said they could look them up.

By twelve, the cartons filled a shelf.

On his birthday Elias went down to the cellar. Daniel sat beneath the desk lamp with his notebook, one finger resting halfway along a line. Around him the shelves had been pulled away from the walls.

"Look, Daddy. I found a strange one. Maybe it fell from space."

He held out the dark, heavy stone.

"Unlikely," Daniel said.

His pencil moved. Elias waited, then put the stone back in his pocket.

Upstairs, Ruth had cut the cake.

"Big piece?"

"Normal."

He could not taste the first mouthful. After that it tasted like cake, and he ate it, and was angry that he wanted another piece.

Daniel came up after the plates were cleared. He kissed the top of Elias's head. His shirt smelled of damp plaster.

"Tomorrow," he said. "We'll do something tomorrow."

His father was a theoretical physicist. Elias learned to say this before he could spell it. Later, when the university stopped calling, he kept saying it. The notebooks multiplied. Equations crowded against passages copied from old stories: a ladder reaching into the sky; a mountain with a passage through it; a door that opened to someone who asked.

At the hospital Daniel sat beneath a television mounted too high on the wall. He asked Elias about school. They had built bridges from paper that week, and Daniel wanted to know how much weight his held. For ten minutes they discussed the supports. When Ruth said it was time to leave, Elias pretended not to hear.

Daniel disappeared when Elias was fifteen.

For a week Ruth left the hall light on. Then she began making calls behind the closed kitchen door. A police officer asked Elias when he had last seen his father and whether they had argued. He remembered Daniel asking him to move his bicycle. He could not remember whether he had done it.

The minerals stayed in their cartons until he left for college. He packed his books about bridges and engines. Engineering offered workshops, things to assemble, answers that could be made to carry a load.

Twenty years later, a search window stood open on his kitchen table.

Upstairs, Sami was getting ready for bed. Elias heard the wardrobe close and his son's feet cross the landing. He saved the page he was reading.

By the time he went up, the light was out.

Seams

The agency did not answer his second message. A week after that, the company named in the advertiser field changed.

The campaign hadn't changed. Same color, same small sunrise, the same line about carrying things alone. Elias saved the new company name beside the first and began looking through the filings he could reach without paying for an account.

He found an address shared by forty-seven businesses. The agency's registered officer appeared in records for a firm that no longer existed. An invoice number printed at the foot of a campaign page led nowhere. He wrote down the dead ends as carefully as the leads.

Beside this list he kept another one, though he never gave the second list a title.

On three Sundays the sparrow had come to the railing at breakfast. Twice he had managed to record it. He placed the clips beside each other and slowed them down. The small head turned. Two hops. The bird vanished beyond the frame.

In one clip a petal fell behind the bird. In the other there was no petal. He aligned the landings, but the timings would not hold through the whole movement. Eventually all he could see were two birds behaving very much alike.

He kept both.

There was also a photograph of light on the kitchen wall. He had remembered the same pattern from another evening and gone looking for the earlier picture. He found six years of photographs, several hundred of Sami, one of Ruth laughing beneath a paper hat. He did not find the light.

At work, a supplier laughed during a call and Elias was certain he had heard that laugh before, in that exact place in a sentence. He almost asked the man to repeat himself.

"Elias? Are you there?"

"Yes. Sorry. Go on."

He didn't add the laugh to the list.

What he could establish was that his father had given a lecture at the university two years before he disappeared. A scan of the program survived in an archive. Beside Daniel's name was a title about time, followed by a surname Elias recognized from Christmas cards.

The other man had retired. His university page contained an email address and a photograph taken in front of a whiteboard. Elias wrote three versions of his message before sending the shortest: his name, his father's name, and a request for a conversation.

The reply came the next afternoon.

Of course. Thursday, if that suits you.

Elias took the call in his parked car. The man spoke softly and occasionally moved the phone too far from his mouth.

"I remember you," he said. "You came to a department picnic. Very serious about a kite."

"That sounds right."

"Your father said the wind was wrong. You told him it was the string."

Elias watched someone return a shopping cart to a rack across the lot.

"Who was right?"

"I can't remember. I'm sorry. I remember the argument."

For a while they talked about the university. His father had liked teaching small groups, disliked committees, brought lunch in a tin that would not quite close. Elias had forgotten the tin. Daniel had used a rubber band to hold the lid down.

"Did he ever talk about leaving?"

"The department?"

"Everything."

The man was quiet.

"Not to me."

"What was he working on at the end?"

"He was asking what a measurement can tell us about the world making it possible. Time, chiefly. He thought there were discrepancies other people were treating as inconveniences."

"Were there?"

"There are always discrepancies. The difficulty is finding out which ones survive the apparatus."

"And his did?"

"Some didn't. I don't know about the rest."

A car door slammed nearby. Elias moved the phone to his other ear and watched the shop doors open and close.

"People told me he was ill."

"I wasn't his doctor."

"I'm not asking you to be."

"No." The man let out a breath. "He was a good colleague for a long time. Better than good. Toward the end he missed appointments. You would ask him something and he would answer the question he had brought into the room. I was concerned. I also owed him a proper reading of his last paper, and I never gave it one. Both of those things are true."

"Do you have it?"

"Not that draft. I kept the published work. I wish I'd kept more."

Elias thanked him.

"How is your mother?"

"She's living with us."

"Please give her my regards, if she remembers me. She was very kind when my wife was sick."

He remained in the car after they hung up. Then he called Lena to say he was on his way. She reminded him to buy milk. At the shop he picked up the wrong kind, put it back, and stood in front of the refrigerator until he remembered which they needed.

That night he dreamed of the house where he had grown up.

Nothing unusual happened in it. He was standing halfway down the stairs, looking at a strip of afternoon light beneath the kitchen door. From somewhere farther inside came a low dragging sound, then a hush. It repeated while he stood there. He couldn't decide if someone was moving a chair or drawing a curtain along its rail.

When he woke, his hand was resting against the wall beside the bed.

He listened. Lena was asleep. There was a car on the road, receding, and then the house settled into quiet.

In the morning he remembered the light under the door more clearly than the sound. He tried to remember whether the kitchen in that house had ever had a door that closed. By breakfast he wasn't sure.

The Notebook

Ruth wanted the photograph in which she wore the green dress.

They went through the album together. There was Ruth beside a stone wall, Ruth holding a baby, Ruth turning away from a table crowded with people Elias could no longer name. None was the one she wanted.

"The wardrobe," she said at last.

The box stood behind a folded blanket on the top shelf. He had tried to move it when they made space for her clothes, but she would not let him. Now she watched him lift it down.

"The bottom," she said.

He put his other hand beneath it. An old strip of tape had come loose.

Inside were envelopes of photographs, birthday cards, a spare button sewn to a rectangle of fabric. Ruth found the green dress in the second envelope. She stood beside Daniel on a balcony, water nearly white behind them.

"It didn't crease," she said. "You could take it out of the suitcase and put it straight on."

She held the photograph while Elias examined the split in the box. Under the cards lay a dark notebook with a cloth spine. Its lower edge had swollen and dried unevenly. A piece of green wax clung beside the binding.

He sat on the carpet.

Daniel's name was on the first page. Further in, leaves had been cut close to the spine. Receipts and scraps of paper lay between diagrams; sentences climbed the margins in his father's small, impatient hand.

Then the colored tree.

Green between the branches, yellow on the winding line, the fruit red enough to have marked the page beneath. Near the margin lay the stroke Elias had made when Daniel took the book away.

He put his thumb beside it. His hand covered most of the drawing now.

The colors were dull with dust. When he bent the page, a flake of green loosened. He straightened it at once. Beneath the wax he could make out the pressure of numbers, though not the numbers themselves.

He turned carefully to the next drawing. Without the color it was harder to see a tree. Lines gathered in knots, divided, ran together again. One had been erased so often that the paper was almost transparent. Dozens of versions followed, the same small point placed steadily among the corrections.

Ruth held her photograph against the blanket. Her eyes were closed.

Elias put the envelopes back as she liked them. The notebook stayed on his knee.

Lena found him there. He was unfolding a brittle notice about property beneath the river. It had a station name, an address for correspondence, and a word Daniel had circled at the foot.

Sower.

"What's that?" she asked.

He turned too quickly. A little tear opened along the paper's fold.

"His book."

Lena knelt beside him. He showed her the colored page.

"You did that?"

"I was six."

She passed her hand above the red fruit without touching it.

"You pressed hard."

"I wanted him to see."

Ruth stirred. They waited for her to settle, and in the quiet Lena looked at the other pages, the loose notice, his phone beside them on the floor.

"Is this what keeps you up?"

He folded the notice along a different crease.

"I've been looking again."

"I know."

There was no accusation in it. That made it harder to answer.

He almost told her about the sound, the light beneath the door in his dream. Instead he showed her a saved picture of the blue advertisement.

She read it and gave the phone back.

"Have you called?"

"Why would I?"

"Because you aren't sleeping. Because you keep telling me you're fine."

He looked down at the book. Her eyes moved to Ruth and back to him.

"I'm not him," he said.

"I didn't say you were."

From downstairs Sami called that he had found an ant carrying something larger than itself. Lena stayed beside Elias for a moment, then got up.

"Come and see."

He left the book on the carpet and followed her. By the time they reached the garden, the ant had disappeared beneath the paving. Sami knew where it had gone. He led them to the place and crouched, waiting for it to come out again.

That night Elias brought the notebook to the kitchen table. He laid the fragile notice on a clean sheet and photographed it. Enlarged on the screen, the station name was clear.

Above him a floorboard moved. He closed the image before Lena reached the stairs.

Two Trails

Sami was singing in the bath when Elias heard the words.

He had been repairing the linen-cupboard catch. One screw no longer held in the wood. He stood with the little brass fitting in his hand while the tune came through the bathroom door.

Don't have to carry it, carry it, carry it alooooone.

He put the catch on the floor.

"Where did you hear that?"

Sami looked up. Water dripped from the plastic cup in his hand.

"That song."

Elias crouched beside the bath. The boy turned away, embarrassed, and he caught his arm.

"Who taught you?"

"Your phone, I think. You had a - Dad. You're hurting."

He let go. Pale places filled with color on Sami's wet skin.

Lena stood in the doorway with a towel over her shoulder.

"Move back," she said.

Sami reached for her, although he usually insisted on getting out himself. She wrapped him in the towel and took him to their room.

Elias stayed beside the bath. The cup drifted against the side, turned, drifted back. In the hall he stepped on the cupboard catch.

Later he knocked at the bedroom door. Sami had Lena's book across his knees and was looking at a page without turning it.

"I shouldn't have grabbed you," Elias said. "You didn't do anything wrong."

The boy rubbed a corner of the cover.

"I wasn't doing it at you."

"I know. I'm sorry."

He waited. From the bathroom came the sound of the last water running out.

"I want Mom tonight," Sami said.

Elias nodded and went downstairs.

One of his saved campaign pages still opened. Beneath the video was a credit he had not followed before. It led to the foundation that had commissioned the advertisements.

The song was in the second video.

A woman stood at a sink. A kettle boiled behind her. Four notes carried the words underneath the image. He had played it with Sami beside him, trying to show him a photograph of a bridge made from a shoebox.

He remembered the video. He could not remember the bridge.

Lena came down and found him watching it.

"It was mine," he said.

She listened long enough to hear the line. Then she pulled out a chair.

"He's ten, Elias."

He turned the phone face down.

They sat until she went back upstairs. He fitted the cupboard catch before bed, plugging the worn hole so the screw would hold.

The following evening Sami needed a piece of his school project held while he fetched glue. He gave it to Elias without looking at him. Elias stood where he had been left, the little piece balanced in his palm, until the boy returned.

Only after the house was quiet did he open the foundation's website again.

There were annual reports, names, photographs of rooms where people sat in circles. He found accounts for telephone services and home visits. The address on the contact page was real. He looked at it on a map, then called the number the next morning from his car.

The woman who answered offered to put him through to someone.

"I want to know why you keep sending me things about my father."

She asked him to send an example. He did it while she remained on the line. She did not tell him he was mistaken.

"I'll ask someone to contact you," she said.

He gave his name and number. Afterward he sat for a while with the phone on the passenger seat, watching people enter the office building.

That night the notebook yielded a property reference he had mistaken for a telephone number. He searched it in the city records.

The first result was a lease.

Most of the page concerned maintenance and water entering the lower levels. The tenant bore the name his father had circled. Its address was a station on the old river spur, a stop that no longer appeared on the current map.

Later records referred him to schedules he could not find. He obtained a plan of a passage under the river, then a fire certificate too blurred to read. At its edge someone had drawn a small rectangle and written *access*.

He laid the papers beside the foundation's report.

When Lena came down for water, he put the notebook over them. She looked at the table, then at him. Neither spoke.

The next afternoon his phone rang while he was making tea for Ruth.

"Elias? My name is Hesk. You spoke to someone at the foundation."

He set down the kettle.

She said she could discuss the messages by phone, or he could come in. She gave him an address beside the river and described an entrance next to an old ticket office.

He looked toward the papers on the table.

"The station?"

"Yes."

In the sunroom Ruth called for him. He told her he would be a moment and moved the phone closer.

"Did you know Daniel?"

The silence changed.

"Your father?"

"Yes."

"I met him."

Ruth called again. Elias stood in the kitchen with her tea cooling beside his hand.

The Institute

The entrance was beside a shuttered ticket office. A square of cleaner brick marked the place where a sign had been removed.

Elias arrived early and walked past. Beyond the station the river moved under a skin of reflected windows. A cyclist rang a bell because he had stopped in the path. He moved aside, watched a barge pass beneath the bridge, and waited until the hour Hesk had given him.

The lock released when he pressed the bell.

Inside, cream tiles became green halfway down the stairs. The air was cool and smelled faintly of floor polish. At the bottom a man in a pale coat took his name and showed him into a waiting room.

There were six chairs and no clock. Through an interior window an attendant folded garments onto a trolley. One wheel clicked each time it turned.

Hesk entered carrying tea. Her hair was pinned with a black clip. He had expected someone older, although he could not have said how old she was.

"I'm glad you came," she said.

He remained beside his chair. "You knew my father."

"He came to us. Sit down, Elias. The tea will get cold."

She set a cup before him and took the chair opposite. She did not open the folder on her lap.

"Your message said he disappeared twenty years ago."

"He did."

"That is a long time to be waiting."

Elias looked at the cup. It had a fine crack beneath the glaze, running from the handle toward the base.

"Did he ask you not to tell us?"

Hesk rested her hands on the folder.

"Your father wanted time. He believed he would be able to explain himself afterward."

He sat down slowly. Beyond the glass, the trolley had stopped. The attendant was holding a shirt against her shoulder to fold it.

"My mother waited for that explanation."

"I know."

"Do you?"

For the first time Hesk looked away. She let the question remain between them.

He unfolded the lease and placed it on the table. She read the circled name, then the date.

"This was before my work here. Where did you find it?"

"In his book."

He showed her the drawing. Her eyes moved over the page without the surprise he had expected. He could not tell whether she had seen it before or had simply learned to conceal surprise.

"And the messages?" he said.

She put the lease beside the book.

"I arranged for someone to reach you. You didn't answer. Then you complained, and I could speak to you myself."

"You could have told me about him."

"Would you have heard anything else?"

The sharp answer he wanted would not come. He remembered Sami pulling his arm away in the bath. He closed the notebook.

Hesk leaned forward.

"You don't need to bring me an explanation for everything that's happened. You can begin with whatever is keeping you awake. Or we can sit here until the tea is finished."

He looked at the closed door behind her. It had a narrow pane of wired glass. A man passed on the other side wearing loose trousers and carrying his shoes.

"I want the messages to stop."

"All right."

She wrote on the front of the folder. For a while there was only the pencil and the sound of someone speaking in the corridor.

Elias could have told her about the sound at night. He could have described the stairs in his dream, the light beneath the kitchen door. He watched her put the pencil away.

"I'd like to see him," he said.

Hesk looked at him for a long moment.

"There are things you may find difficult. Coming here won't make him the father you remember."

"I don't remember him very well."

She rose and went to the wired-glass door. He followed. Beyond it, a corridor ran toward a brighter space. Somewhere out of sight, footsteps climbed and descended a staircase. He heard a low voice, almost familiar, and leaned nearer the glass.

His phone vibrated.

Lena had asked him to buy bread. Under her message Sami had sent a photograph of an enormous biscuit with icing eyes. He had placed a ruler beside it.

Elias looked from the screen to the corridor.

"Not today."

Hesk nodded. She walked him to the stairs. At the foot of them he asked whether she had told Daniel to go home.

"I asked what was waiting for him there."

"And?"

She held the outer door open for him.

"Ask him."

At the shop, Elias stood in the queue behind a woman choosing between two loaves. When his turn came, he could not remember which kind Lena wanted.

He took home the wrong one. He said there had been a queue and left it at that.

That evening the blue advertisements stopped. A coat occupied one space, a holiday another. He opened several pages to make sure, then deleted the tabs before Lena came downstairs.

Five nights later he dreamed of a corridor.

He was carrying a cup he could not put down. Every shelf was just beyond his reach. At the far end a door stood open, but he could see no room beyond it. A low movement passed through the floor. It stopped. When it came again, the cup trembled against his fingers.

He woke with one arm outside the blanket and rain ticking at the window.

Lena touched his shoulder. "Bad dream?"

"I don't remember."

He lay awake after she had gone back to sleep, holding the shape of the corridor in his mind.

The Recital

Sami's recital was on a Thursday.

Lena put it on the kitchen calendar and Elias put it in his phone. Sami wrote *FRONT ROW* on a yellow square of paper and stuck it to the case of Elias's laptop. The paper remained there for nine days. Twice Elias took the computer to work with it attached.

On Thursday he finished early. He sent his last result to the team and left before anyone could give him something else.

At the flower stall he bought the small yellow flowers Sami liked. The stallholder wrapped their stems in wet paper. Elias put them on the passenger seat, moved them so the sun would not fall on them, and went back to pay for the parking.

That was when he saw the envelope under the wiper.

There was no name on it. Inside was a single photocopied page.

He recognized the shape before he recognized the handwriting: the branching figure, the line curving through it, the little filled circle. On this version there were groups of numbers beside several of the branches. The page number in the corner was one he did not remember seeing.

He stood beside the car and checked the street. A delivery van was reversing into a loading space. Across the road, a man was lifting a child out of a buggy. Nobody was looking at him.

He photographed the page and sent it to the number from which Hesk had called.

Did this come from you?

Then he got into the car.

He took the notebook from his bag and looked for the page number. The leaves cut close to the spine made a small uneven comb against his thumb.

The page was not there.

He began comparing the drawing with the last complete drawing in the notebook. One branch joined another in a different place. A patch of

shadow on the photocopy might have been part of a thumb. He enlarged the photograph until the numbers broke into squares.

The first reminder sounded.

He dismissed it. He was still early. The hall was a fifteen-minute drive, perhaps twenty in the evening traffic. He had time to check whether the groups were coordinates.

They did not fit any arrangement he tried. One number was too large; another had too many places. He searched the longer sequence in quotation marks and received no results. He tried it without the marks. A component catalogue appeared, then an old article in a language he could not read. Neither led anywhere.

Hesk replied.

No. Keep the envelope. You can bring it when you next come.

He asked whether she recognized the drawing. While he waited, he opened another search.

Lena called.

He looked at her name on the screen. If he answered, she would ask where he was, and he would have to put the page away. He let the call finish and typed *Leaving shortly*.

There was time if he left now.

He put the notebook back in the bag, then noticed that one of the numbers on the copy appeared beside a different branch on Daniel's older drawing. He took the book out again.

When he finally turned the key, the flowers had slipped into the footwell. The phone showed another missed call and a message he did not want to open. He opened it anyway.

He's about to go on.

He could still have driven there. He sat holding the wheel, calculating how late he would be, which door he might enter by, whether Sami would see him arrive halfway through the piece. The numbers on the page were easier to look at.

The hall had emptied by the time he passed it. A man was stacking folding chairs inside the open side door. Elias slowed without stopping.

At home, Lena was putting Sami's polished shoes back in their box.

"I called," she said.

"I know."

"He left you a place."

Elias held out the flowers without meaning to. She looked at them and then back at him.

"Put them in water."

He went into the kitchen. His hands made a clumsy job of the wet wrapping. When he returned, Lena was still standing by the stairs.

"Something came up with work," he said.

She did not answer.

He looked toward the laptop on the table. The yellow square was still attached to it.

"No. That isn't true."

Lena waited.

"I was looking for something about Dad. I lost track."

"When you sent me that message, were you leaving?"

"No."

She put the lid on the shoe box.

"I told him you were on your way."

He could think of nothing to say to that. He followed her upstairs carrying the vase, then went back down and left it in the kitchen.

Sami was sitting on his bed with his recital shirt still on. The top button was undone and the hem hung over his pajama trousers. He had a programme in his lap.

"Can I come in?" Elias asked.

"You're here."

He stayed beside the door.

"I'm sorry I missed it. I said I'd come, and I didn't."

"Mom said you were driving."

"I told her I was going to. Then I stayed where I was. She didn't know."

Sami rubbed a fold into the programme with his thumbnail.

"Did you forget?"

Elias could hear the invitation in the question. An ordinary mistake, a repairable one. He had forgotten appointments before.

"No."

The boy folded the paper again.

"I kept looking. Then I stopped."

"I know."

"You don't."

Elias nodded once. "You're right."

They stayed like that until Sami asked whether he could get changed. Elias closed the door from the outside.

Later Lena sat at the kitchen table with the recital programme. Beside Sami's name she had penciled a small star.

"I'm not going to tell him you're on your way again," she said.

Elias looked at the flowers. One had bent while it lay in the footwell. He had propped it against the others, but it was slipping.

"I won't ask you to."

She turned the programme so he could read it and went upstairs.

The next morning Sami found him making toast.

"What were you looking for?"

Elias turned the heat down. "Something your grandfather drew."

"The one in Grandma's pictures?"

"Yes."

"What is it?"

"I think it might be a map. I haven't worked out how to read it."

Sami considered this. "Will you show me when you do?"

"I'll tell you what I understand. You can look at it with me."

"Not now."

"All right."

The boy took the plate Elias offered. At the kitchen door he stopped.

"Mom recorded the piano."

"Would you like me to hear it?"

Sami looked down at the toast. "Later."

Elias left the time to him.

What Ruth Knew

Ruth died on a Tuesday.

For the last fortnight she had slept through the hours when she used to ask for the garden. Elias carried breakfast into the sunroom and carried most of it out again. The blue plate pleased her for a day. Then she no longer seemed to notice which one he used.

That morning she asked for the curtains to be opened.

Lena's print stood beneath the window, a study of lemon leaves with one edge slightly out of place. Ruth watched the real branch move behind it.

"She made that?"

"Yes."

"It's lovely."

He reached to straighten the paper.

"Leave it," she said.

He brought his chair closer instead. Her handbag stood under the little table. He could see the clasp she had insisted on fastening herself.

"Was there somewhere you wanted to go?" he asked.

Ruth turned toward him. For a moment her expression was so clear that he felt himself becoming a boy beside her chair.

"I wanted my life with you."

He lowered his head.

She moved her fingers into his hand. "Don't carry it like a debt."

Outside, a lawn mower stopped. In the silence he could hear a fly working against the window. He wanted to ask about Daniel, about the place beside the river. Ruth had closed her eyes.

"Window open?"

"A little."

He let the insect out and sat down again.

Lena returned with Sami. The boy stood beside his grandmother and told her something about school. She seemed to listen. After he had gone

upstairs, Elias and Lena stayed, one on either side of the chair. Later there was no answering pressure from Ruth's fingers. Her hand remained warm in his for a while.

The next days were full of names and dates. Lena found the clothes Ruth had once asked her to set aside. Elias had not known they had spoken about it. A neighbor brought back three containers from meals Ruth had sent over years before. He put them in the cupboard and kept expecting to tell her they were home.

The notebook stayed in its drawer.

On the first Wednesday, Lena offered to miss her class. He told her to go. When she returned, he and Sami were on the kitchen floor holding a glued joint together. The boy was deciding when it would be safe to let go.

One evening Sami brought him the recording of the recital.

"The sound isn't very good," he said.

Someone coughed at the beginning. Lena's hand scraped the phone. Then the music started, and Elias watched his son sit straight-backed at an instrument too large for him.

At the difficult bar, Sami drew breath beside him. The little figure on the screen hesitated, found the next note, and went on.

When it ended, neither spoke. Sami reached across and started it again.

Three weeks after the funeral, Elias opened the drawer.

The Door

In the dream he was at the kitchen table.

The notebook lay open, its pages empty. Someone stood in the next room. Elias could see a hand lifted beside the door, but not whether the palm faced him. He tried to speak.

Beneath the floor the low sound began. It rose, paused, returned. This time there was almost a word in it. He leaned forward, certain he would understand if it came once more.

Lena was saying his name.

The bedroom was pale. A delivery vehicle idled in the street. When it moved off, he remained upright, listening.

"You were talking," she said.

He rubbed his face.

"Your father?"

He looked at her. She had raised herself on one elbow, waiting.

"I couldn't see him."

She moved the blanket so he could lie down. He did, but kept his eyes on the window until she slept.

That afternoon he took the notebook from the drawer and put the loose page inside it. The envelope from the car was still folded behind the cover. For a while he sat with the book across his knees.

Then he called Hesk.

She did not ask him to begin again. When he said he wanted to come, she gave him a time.

At dusk Lena was washing rice in the kitchen. Water whitened around her fingers. Sami had gone upstairs after practising; the last few notes were still in Elias's head.

"I'm going out," he said.

Lena stopped moving the rice.

"Will you eat here?"

He looked at the open cupboard, the three plates she had taken down.

"Don't wait for me."

She turned off the tap. He thought she might ask where, and had an answer ready that would tell her very little. Instead she put the bowl on the counter and dried her hands.

"Elias."

He waited in the doorway.

She crossed the room and straightened the fold of his collar. For a moment her hands stayed there. Then she went back to the rice.

He passed through the living room and the enclosed porch. Outside, the first lamps were coming on. He pulled the front door shut carefully so the latch would not wake his mother.

His hand remained on it after he remembered.

The streets near the river were unfamiliar in the dark. He drove past the turning and came back, following a row of wet rails embedded in the road. When he found a space, he sat in the car until the engine had stopped ticking.

The station clock was visible through the windscreen. He checked it against his phone, then put the phone away. He took the notebook and stepped out. The car door closed with a solid, reassuring sound.

At the station a woman was trying to lift a stroller through the barrier. He held the gate for her. She thanked him without looking up. The child watched him over her shoulder as they descended toward the trains.

He took the other staircase.

The old river passage began beyond a tiled arch. A notice promised access to the opposite entrance, though someone had drawn a line through the little pedestrian on it. The line was faded. Below, in smaller print, were hours he could not read.

Hesk had said the passage would be open.

A door stood against its stop. Elias went through.

Light pooled beneath widely spaced fixtures. Between them the curved ceiling disappeared. There were tiles here too, their glaze blistered in places, and a darker band at shoulder height where water had once reached. His footsteps travelled ahead of him and returned less clearly.

He had walked this way only in daylight, from the entrance on the other bank. He remembered a short descent, the bell, Hesk coming to meet him. The plan in Daniel's notebook had not made the tunnel look long.

A pale rectangle waited at the far end.

He walked toward it. At each light he expected the next stretch to be shorter. The rectangle remained small. Somewhere in the wall water ran with the steady hurry of a tap left open.

He passed a loose tile, then another. He began counting the lights and lost his place while trying to remember whether he had included the first. He stopped.

Without his footsteps the tunnel seemed longer.

He took out the phone. The screen showed his own face before it lit: hollow eyes, the dark collar of his coat. There was no signal. He looked at the time and could not remember what it had been at the car.

The water continued behind the wall.

He put the phone away. When he began walking again, his first step sounded much too loud. The notebook had grown warm beneath his arm. He changed sides and kept going.

At last the rectangle widened into a door. Its wire-glass pane held a yellow light. Beside it was the small metal bell he remembered.

He pressed it.

Hesk opened before he had taken his finger away.

"You're cold," she said. "Come in."

The air smelled of clean cloth and boiled water. She led him past reception, where a man was filling a kettle at a little sink. The waiting-room chairs had been turned toward a television without sound. Elias recognized a vase he had not noticed on his first visit.

He handed Hesk the envelope. She put it in his folder. The copied page remained inside the notebook.

At the center of the building the corridor opened around a stairwell.

He looked up. Landings repeated above him, pale rails against deeper shadow. Someone in a loose white shirt crossed the highest one he could see. Below, a woman descended with one hand moving along the banister. A door opened, spilling brightness across the stairs, then closed before he could see who had passed through it.

"This way," Hesk said.

She held an inner door for him. The stairwell disappeared behind its frosted pane.

In a small room she placed a form on the table. His name was already at the top. He read it several times before beginning to fill the spaces beneath. There were dates he knew and a question about sleep. Under *Reason for coming*, he wrote his father's name.

Hesk waited until he laid down the pen.

"You'll be able to see him," she said. "But you may not find him ready to leave."

"I know."

He had said it too quickly. She let him sit a little longer.

An attendant brought a folded gown and showed him a screened alcove. His coat, wallet, phone, and keys went into a locker. His shoes looked strangely formal beneath it. The attendant gave him slippers and a thin robe, then pointed to the notebook.

"With you?"

He nodded.

The cotton was soft from washing. A seam at the shoulder had been repaired with slightly different thread. He ran his thumb over it while Hesk checked that he had everything he meant to keep.

They walked down a quieter corridor. From one room came a man's voice, patient and emphatic, explaining something to someone who did not answer. Elias slowed. Hesk waited for him at the next door.

The voice stopped.

She opened the door and he went in.

Stars covered the ceiling.

He stood just inside while his eyes adjusted. The room was larger than he had expected. A chair faced the brightest part of the dome; beside it stood a table with a glass of water. There was a faint mark on the floor where another chair had been.

Hesk drew the robe closer around his shoulders before he sat.

"Put the book where it won't fall."

He held it across his knees.

She moved toward the door. The light of the corridor made a long, narrowing shape beside his feet.

"Was he frightened?" Elias asked.

Hesk rested her hand on the handle.

"He wanted to know what came next."

She left the door open. Voices moved beyond it. The trolley passed with its uneven wheel. Elias listened until he could no longer hear it.

He drank some water.

Above him one of the stars seemed to draw away. He blinked, and it was where it had been, though the darkness around it had acquired a depth he could not follow. He looked for the edge of the ceiling.

He had seen it a moment before.

The chair pressed differently against his back. He shifted, trying to regain the position in which he had been sitting. The book slid; he caught it by its worn spine.

Another star receded. A group of faint points appeared between two he had mistaken for neighbors.

He waited for the room to steady.

The rectangle of corridor light was gone. He had not heard the door close. His feet no longer rested flat on the floor, and when he reached beside him his hand found a padded seam, a hard rim, a strap hanging loose.

He was lying more than sitting.

Beyond his feet a pale floor curved away into shadow. The stars lay beyond a long dark pane. A reflection moved across it as he raised his head.

Cold air touched his face.

He kept hold of the book.

Cold

A woman stood beside the couch with a cup in her hand.

She waited for him to look at her before she spoke.

"Slowly."

He tried to sit. The robe had twisted beneath him, pinning one arm. She freed it and helped him raise the cup. Water touched his teeth, painfully cold at first. He swallowed too much and coughed.

"I did say."

There was nothing unkind in her voice. She took the cup while he caught his breath, then returned it.

The notebook lay beside his hip. He touched it before drinking again.

Beyond the pane were stars, steady and sharp. Across one edge of the view lay a pale surface, rough as broken chalk. Little lamps picked out a railing and something moving very slowly beyond it. Elias followed the movement until it passed behind the frame.

"Where am I?"

"Stay sitting for a minute."

She had a dark mark at the base of her thumb and a patch on one sleeve. He watched her pull a chair closer. Its feet scraped the floor.

"I'm Rana. Tell me if you feel sick."

He shook his head, then wished he hadn't.

She waited with him.

Behind her, a corridor curved beyond an open door. Someone crossed it carrying a shallow tray. For an instant Elias expected to hear the wheel of Hesk's trolley. The person was gone before he could see what was on the tray.

"The woman who brought me - "

"You can stand when you're ready. There's no hurry."

He placed his feet beneath him. The slippers were still on. Rana put out a hand but let him take his own weight. He stood, swayed, and caught the edge of the couch.

"There," she said.

He looked down at himself: the gown, the robe with its repaired seam, his hand white against the dark upholstery. There was a red mark where the notebook had pressed into his palm.

She brought him loose trousers and a shirt. A curtain drew across the doorway. When he had changed, she showed him where to fold the robe. He left the notebook on top of it and then picked it up again.

In the next room a bowl stood on a table fixed to the wall. Something warm and plain smelled of grain. He sat and discovered that he was hungry.

Rana leaned against the doorway while he ate. Beyond her, a man called her name. She lifted one finger to him.

"I'll be close," she told Elias.

"What is this place?"

She looked toward the window. For a moment he thought she had not understood the question.

"Where we work."

The man called again. This time she went.

Elias put down the spoon. On the opposite wall, beneath a cupboard, a little light brightened and became still. He listened for people, for wheels, for water in a pipe. The room was quiet enough for him to hear himself swallow.

A woman's voice spoke near him.

"Lena and Sami are at home, Elias. They are alive."

He turned so quickly that the spoon fell.

"They are as real as you are," the voice said. "Nothing you have seen here takes that away."

He held the edge of the table. The spoon lay on the floor by his foot.

"Who are you?"

"My name is Haven. Let me tell you where you've come."

The Steward

Elias searched the room for a face.

There was the open door, the little light below the cupboard, his own dim reflection in the window. Outside it, the rough white surface disappeared into darkness. The grain in his bowl had begun to cool.

"You are aboard a vessel," Haven said. "It carries the world you know. Your wife has her own thoughts while you are absent. Your son goes on being your son. They are not waiting for you to look at them before they can live."

He bent to retrieve the spoon and found that his hand was shaking. He left it on the table.

"The Earth your ancestors came from is gone. So is the Sun that warmed it. I know those are words too large to put beside the kitchen you left. You don't have to do it all at once."

A faint line crossed the window, the reflection of someone passing behind him. He looked round. No one entered.

"Long before its oceans boiled away," Haven continued, "long before the Sun became a name in an archive, humanity asked how a species might survive the end of its world.

"Some looked first to the body. They imagined people who could breathe under unfamiliar skies, endure radiation, sleep through the long dark between stars. Each change opened another possibility. Each also took them further from the people they meant to save. They argued about where survival ended and replacement began. There was no number they could agree upon.

"Others imagined ships filled with families. Children would learn the names of rivers they had never seen. Gardens would grow beneath lamps; generations would tend them until another sun appeared ahead. It was a brave answer. But a garden is more than its plants. A small failure could pass from the soil to the food, from the food to the people, until everything depended on something no one had thought to count. In the futures I could examine, I could not make those ships endure for as long as I believed they must.

"There were planets. There were always people willing to leave for them. A world could offer more room than any vessel, and dangers no vessel had taught them to survive. To settle one might buy an age. I was looking for a way to carry them beyond the end of that age too.

"Moons were hollowed in drawings. Cities were suspended in the dark. Plans grew around small stars. Some might have worked for a very long time. None answered every part of what my makers asked of me."

Haven fell quiet.

Elias could see the kitchen table, so distinctly that for a moment he expected the notebook beside his bowl to stand on its familiar scratch in the wood.

"Let us live," she said. "Let us remember. Let us remain human.

"I was young then. They had made me to help them, and they did not always agree about what help should be. One asked me to end pain. Another asked what a life would mean if nothing could be lost. They wanted their children to grow beyond them and feared what the children might become. I listened. The more I learned, the less their contradictions resembled errors.

"When the time came to choose, I tried to preserve more than bodies. A person alone is not a people. A list of names is not a family. I needed the quarrels and the music, the languages in which a child could ask for water, the work someone did because another person needed it. I needed lives that continued when I was not watching.

"The answer I chose was the Arks. Vessels like this one, carrying three kinds of world.

"The first was the place in which people could go on living together. At the beginning it was a simulation. We made approximations because they were all we could make. We kept what worked while we learned to do more. There are still old things beneath your world, things that repeat when they should change."

The sparrow came back to him: its little head turning, the two hops, his own image bent over the recordings.

"In time I learned to sustain an instance of reality on another substrate. I can tell you that name; I cannot make it familiar in a sentence. A woman can plant a tree there and grow old beneath it. Her child can love her and

misunderstand her and miss her when she dies. Those things are not less real because you have come here.

"I gave that world a shape drawn from an age people remembered with affection. There had been enough food for many, more time, more freedom to make something of a life. It was never a perfect age. I have had a long time to decide what I should change, and I have changed less than some would wish.

"I think of what people do for their parents when the parents can no longer keep the house themselves. They mend what is broken. They put familiar things where a hand will find them. They try to help without taking the whole life away. Sometimes they mistake one for the other. I have too.

"The second world is the Library. It holds the inheritance of bodies: human lineages, the forms of plants and animals, the knowledge that lets a living thing become more than a record. Much of what we carry has not been grown for ages. We keep the possibility. A seed need not be a forest today to matter tomorrow.

"The third is where you are sitting. The Vessel. Stone, ice, metal, rooms warm enough for a few people. Most live in the worlds within. Some come out to work. They tend the things that let the others sleep, wake, fall in love, have children, and forget to notice the weather.

"We move when we must. We gather what we need. We repair what fails. Around us are distances through which whole civilizations once expected to travel, and we cross them carrying ordinary days.

"I do not promise that we will last forever. I made a promise to keep them as long as I could.

"We wander the stars not toward a final home, but away from extinction. The home is what we carry."

For a while Elias did not move.

Someone in the corridor set down a tool. The small, hard sound reached him with surprising clarity. He looked at his hands beside the bowl.

"My mother," he said.

Haven waited.

"Was there somewhere you could have taken her?"

He saw Ruth trying to recognize the spoon, apologizing when she could not. He had wished the end would be gentle. Now there was this room, this voice, all that time beyond the window.

"I cannot give her back to you, Elias."

He lowered his head. Haven said nothing more while he cried.

When he could look up again, the bowl was cold. Rana appeared at the door with fresh water. She replaced the cup and rested a hand briefly on his shoulder before leaving. He watched until she turned out of sight.

"How do you know this isn't another one?" he asked. He moved his hand toward the room, the window, the stars. "Another world somebody is keeping?"

"I don't."

He waited.

"I spent ten thousand years looking for a difference I could measure. Eventually I stopped."

"That doesn't mean there isn't an answer."

"No."

It was the first answer she had given him that felt small enough to hold.

He rose and took the notebook. The corridor outside curved gently. Ahead, Rana stood beside an opening in the wall, supporting a length of pipe while someone worked below it. She glanced toward him.

"A hand?"

He put the book on a ledge and took the weight where she showed him. Warmth travelled through the metal into his palm. The person below loosened a fitting. Rana moved her grip and the load eased.

"There," she said. "Thank you."

A cloth was passed up. He wiped the dust from his hands and picked up the book.

Further along the corridor, a door stood open. Beyond it were shelves, a desk lamp, the pale edge of a window.

"Your father is waiting," Haven said.

Elias stopped walking.

For a moment he listened to Rana and the other worker behind him, continuing what they had been doing.

Then he went on.

Daniel

His father sat beneath a desk lamp with an open notebook.

Elias stopped in the doorway.

The room was crowded with papers. A long display covered one wall; under it stood two chairs, one holding a folded coat. Instruments faced the window. Someone had repaired the handle of a cupboard with tape.

Daniel's pencil moved halfway down a line and stopped.

He looked up.

For a few seconds neither spoke. Then his father pushed back his chair. He had grown older around the eyes. His hair was almost white. Elias had imagined both changes often enough; the familiar way he put the pencil down was harder to bear.

"Elias."

Daniel took a step and waited.

Elias crossed the room. His father's hands closed against his back. He smelled warm cloth, paper, something metallic. They held each other awkwardly, then let go before either seemed ready.

Daniel pulled out the spare chair and lifted the coat from it.

Elias set the notebook on the desk.

His father touched the worn spine. "Your mother kept it."

"She died."

The hand became still.

"A few weeks ago. I was with her."

Daniel sat. He looked toward the window, then down at the book. One of the instruments made a little adjustment behind him. He pressed his palms together until the knuckles whitened.

"Did she ask for me?"

"She thought you were at work."

His father closed his eyes.

Elias watched the light on his face. It was the same color as the lamp in the cellar.

"I told her you'd come back later."

They sat without speaking. On the desk, beside an empty cup, lay a photograph folded so that only a corner of a house was visible.

"You could have," Elias said.

Daniel nodded.

"But then I couldn't come here again. I thought I needed a little more time."

"Twenty years."

"I know."

A result appeared on the long display. Daniel looked at it before he could stop himself. Elias saw the movement, and his father saw him see it. He turned the display dark.

"Is it what you were looking for?"

"No. Not yet."

He rubbed the side of his thumb where the pencil rested.

"Haven thinks she has found enough. She can keep this place for longer than we used to know how to imagine. But even this ends. If there is something beyond it - "

He stopped. Elias waited.

"Here I can ask the question properly. I have instruments I spent my whole life wishing for. Time. People who understand the work. Some mornings I forget to be old."

For an instant he smiled. Then he looked at his son's face.

"I thought I'd bring an answer home. Something worth the time."

"You could have brought yourself."

Daniel lowered his eyes.

The book lay between them. Elias opened it at the colored page. His father's pencil marks rose through the worn green wax.

"I wanted to do what you were doing," Elias said.

Daniel put a finger beside the streak in the margin.

"I remember."

"You were angry."

"Yes."

Neither turned the page.

After a while Elias took out the photocopy. His father studied it, then shook his head before Elias finished asking.

"I didn't send it."

"Where did you first see this?"

Daniel looked from one drawing to the other.

"By the time I could draw it, I wasn't certain I'd seen it at all."

The answer might once have frightened Elias. He folded the copy and put it away.

His father opened a drawer. Inside lay a little cloth pouch. He set it in Elias's hand.

A dark stone slipped out, small and heavy, with a dull silver grain along one edge.

"I meant to bring you that."

Elias turned it beneath the lamp.

"From space?"

Daniel nodded. "When I saw it, I remembered."

The cellar. His own outstretched hand. The word spoken without looking up.

He closed his fingers around the stone.

"A mineral," he said.

His father laughed once, and then could not go on. Elias reached across the desk and held his wrist. They remained that way until Daniel could look at him again.

"Come home with me," Elias said.

His father looked toward the dark display.

The pause lengthened.

"Not yet."

Elias nodded slowly. He put the stone in his pocket and stood. This time Daniel crossed the space between them.

At the door Elias turned. His father was still standing beside the chair, one hand resting on its back.

"I'm glad you came," Daniel said.

"So am I."

He left the door open behind him.

The Message

The window beside the couch was empty of reflections when Elias returned to it.

He put the stone on the sill. Against the stars it looked like something he might have picked up by a road. He turned it until the silver grain caught the room's light.

Rana came past carrying the robe he had left folded in the other room. She laid it beside him.

"You'll want that when you go."

"Have you been here long?"

"Longer than I intended."

She looked out with him. The rough white flank filled one edge of the view.

"I have a sister," she said. "Every time something reminds me of her, I think I ought to go back. Then something needs finishing."

"Will you?"

"I hope so."

She took up the empty cup and went. Her footsteps faded at the curve.

Elias opened the notebook. The fruit was a small red wound in the old paper. He had pressed hard enough to leave its shape on the next page.

"We received something," Haven said.

A panel near the window brightened. Fine threads gathered over it, luminous knots with great dark spaces between. Elias rose and brought the notebook closer.

"Turn it," she said.

He turned the book sideways.

Three forks met where Daniel had drawn them. A branch Elias had colored green stretched across the panel, too large now for his eyes to follow at once.

"Laniakea," Haven said. "Your ancestors gave it that name. Their galaxy was here."

A point brightened. The view moved inward. Around the curve he had always called the serpent, little marks became paths, and the paths separated again. His father's smallest figures lay crowded beside them on the page.

"The drawing holds more than one scale. We have a destination, Elias. A world that may support life. The information describes water, an atmosphere, light we can use. There is much it doesn't tell us."

He touched the paper beside the red circle.

"How did he get it?"

"I don't know."

The panel remained bright. He looked from it to the book and back again.

"Are you going there?"

"We are."

He waited for more. For a name, a face, someone who had stood beneath that other sky. There was only the web of lights and the point inside it.

"You could stay with us," Haven said. "Work here. See what we find. If the world is what the message promises, some will choose to make their lives on it. I will remain as long as I can, then take the worlds I carry onward."

Elias looked toward the corridor his father had gone down. There would be work enough here to fill a lifetime, and after that another. No unanswered question would have to be put away because the hour had grown late.

"How long do people live here?"

"With our care, a thousand years is possible. Some have longer. We cannot prevent every death."

He laid his hand on the window frame. Its surface was warm. A thousand years was harder to imagine than the lights outside.

He thought of the little boy in the cellar, lifting a stone to a man who would not look. He had spent twenty years trying to reach that man. Now Daniel was a short walk away.

The destination turned slowly on the panel.

For a moment Elias saw Sami beneath an unfamiliar sky, older, walking ahead of him. He wanted to call the boy back so he could see his face. The image would not hold.

He closed the notebook and took the stone from the sill.

The Final Decision

Elias sat on the couch with the robe beside him. At the far edge of the window, the small lamps continued to light the railing. The moving shape he had watched before had returned. It stopped where the light ended and lowered itself out of sight.

He could stay. He could learn the instruments in his father's room, work among people who spoke of centuries without lowering their voices. He could see the world at the end of the line Daniel had drawn. The stone fitted the hollow of his palm.

"If I go home," he said, "I can't come back."

"No."

He looked toward the open corridor. "My father knew."

"Yes."

There was no sound from the laboratory. Daniel might be sitting exactly where he had left him. He might have turned the display on again.

Elias put the robe over his knees. The repaired seam lay across his thumb. He remembered Lena straightening his collar, the water standing white around the rice, three plates taken down from the cupboard. For years, whenever he imagined finding his father, the story had ended there.

"I want to go home."

Nothing outside the window changed. He had expected the words to make him certain. Instead he felt the weight of the book, the little stone, the robe warming slowly over his legs. Haven let him sit.

Behind the couch something gave a small, dry tick. A tremor passed through the frame beneath his wrist. Air rose through the narrow grille below the glass, caught, then settled into a long hush.

Elias turned his head. He knew the pause before it came again.

He leaned closer. The air moved steadily now. He waited, but the sound did not recover the shape he remembered.

Along the corridor a door closed. Someone spoke a name he could not make out. Elias stood.

"Go home," Haven said. "Hold your son's hand. Make your wife happy. Enjoy your days."

He lifted the notebook from the couch and put the stone in his pocket. The quiet followed him to the door.

Homecoming

"Honey, I'm home."

His voice sounded strange in the little porch. He closed the front door and waited a moment with his hand on the latch.

From the kitchen came the sound of a cup being set down.

He passed through the living room. Ruth's chair stood beside the window, her blanket folded over its back. On the piano, Sami's music was open at the page with the difficult bar.

The kitchen door stood ajar. Light lay across the floor beyond it.

Lena turned as he entered.

She had always had that smile. It began in her eyes, a tenderness he had once been unable to pass without stopping. Lately he had seen it arrive cautiously, or leave before she finished speaking. Now she set down the cloth in her hand.

"There you are," she said.

He crossed the room and held her. Her hand moved once across his back, then stayed.

Sami had pulled a chair away from the small table. Elias sat beside him, in the place where he had spent so many nights looking into a screen. The laptop was closed on the shelf.

Lena poured coffee. Sunday light caught the steam and for a moment it looked like something alive.

"You missed the bird," she said. "It was trying to carry a piece of string longer than itself. Every time it lifted off, the other end caught in the railing."

"It got it eventually," Sami said.

"With considerable advice from this house."

She smiled at the boy. There were faint lines beside her eyes that Elias did not remember noticing. He watched her turn toward the garden, still telling him about the sparrow, about a lemon that had fallen in the night and the tiny shoots coming up where she had thought nothing would grow.

He could hear all of it. The room was full of light.

Sami reached for the notebook beside his father's cup. Elias opened it for him. The old green wax shone where the page bent.

"You colored it," the boy said.

"When I was little."

Sami traced the air above the red point. "Is it the map?"

"Yes."

"Can I look?"

Elias moved it between them.

The stone touched the edge of the table as he took it from his pocket. Sami lifted it, testing its weight.

"Where did you find this?"

"It was a present."

"What is it?"

Elias looked at the silver grain.

"Let's find out."

Outside, a sparrow landed on the railing and hopped twice to the left. Lena reached across the table for his hand.

"Look at this," she said. "I think we're living in paradise."

He looked at her, then at Sami, turning the stone in the light.

"We are."